domain of missiles we have had an impressive indigenous research and development (R&D) record. Whereas we had started the process of induction of the Prithvi and Agni missile systems in the last few years, it was my privilege as the chief to symbolically receive two mobile 'autonomous launchers' and a mobile command post of the Brahmos supersonic cruise missile system for the army from none other than President A.P.J. Abdul Kalam on the 21 June 2007. This missile project is a fine example of joint R&D by India and Russia, and was led by Dr Shivathanu Pillai, a dynamic scientist. For me personally, it has been a feeling of deep satisfaction to see this system developed. I had witnessed the launch of this missile on two occasions in the Pokharan ranges and observed at first-hand its devastating effect. As stated by Dr Pillai, the naval version of the Brahmos missile is also being inducted in Indian warships and the development of air-launched Brahmos is in progress.

Modernization of the infantry was one of my foremost KRAs. In the type of challenges that we are presently confronted with and are most likely to face in the future, the infantry will continue to be the battle-winning factor. The infantry soldier is thus being progressively transformed by the F-INSAS (Futuristic Infantry Soldier as a System) programme.

'The future infantry soldier must be equipped with tools for better situational awareness, light all-purpose weapons, day-night vision capability, single piece uniform containing climate control and monitoring system … Today's infantry soldier is certainly more operationally capable than his predecessor was a few years ago. He is equipped with a lighter weapon, i.e. INSAS 5.56 … night vision devices and night sights on his weapon system … lighter infantry combat kit than he was carrying earlier … better surveillance and communications system. In a few years from now, we are going to actually see the infantryman holding a hand-held device on which he can at all times know his own position and that of his colleagues and also transmit a message by SMS or by data to his company commander and from there on to his battalion commander. So, we are going to see an army of the future, where a satellite image is received by frontline soldiers and they transmit messages and data